FAITHFUL TO THE END · SESSION 1

Not Ashamed

2 Timothy 1:1–18

TO GET STARTED

Think of a campfire or a fireplace that had almost gone out. What did it take to get it burning again?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Paul is in chains in Rome, around AD 66–67, under the emperor Nero, and he is expecting his execution. This is his last letter – written to his "beloved child" Timothy in Ephesus, who is under heavy pressure and tempted to shrink back. Tonight we read chapter 1: a gift that needs to be rekindled, a gospel we need not be ashamed of, and two very different ways of responding to an apostle in chains.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 1:1–4

[1] Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God, in keeping with the promise of the life that is in Christ Jesus, [2] to Timothy, my beloved child: grace, mercy and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

[3] I am grateful to God, whom I serve with a clear conscience as my forefathers did, when I remember you without ceasing in my prayers, night and day. [4] I long to see you – I remember your tears – so that I may be filled with joy,

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 1:5–8

5 for I have been reminded of the sincere faith that is in you, a faith that lived first in
your grandmother Lois and in your mother Eunice, and I am convinced that it lives
in you as well. 6 For this reason I remind you to rekindle the gift of God that is in you
through the laying on of my hands. 7 For God did not give us a spirit of cowardice,
but of power and of love and of self-control.

8 Do not be ashamed, then, of the testimony about our Lord or of me, his prisoner;
rather, share in hardship for the gospel, in the power of God,

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 1:9–12

9 who saved us and called us with a holy calling, not on the basis of our works but on
the basis of his own purpose and grace, which was given to us in Christ Jesus before
eternal ages, 10 but has now been revealed through the appearing of our Saviour
Jesus Christ, who broke the power of death and brought life and imperishability to
light through the gospel, 11 for which I was appointed a herald and an apostle and a
teacher. 12 That is why I am suffering these things too; but I am not ashamed, for I
know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he is able to guard my
entrusted deposit until that day.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 1:13–17

13 Hold to the example of sound words that you heard from me, in the faith and love
that are in Christ Jesus. 14 Guard the precious thing that has been entrusted to you,
through the Holy Spirit who lives in us.

15 You know that all who are in the province of Asia have turned away from me,
among them Phygelus and Hermogenes. 16 May the Lord grant mercy to the
household of Onesiphorus, for he often refreshed me and was not ashamed of my
chain. 17 On the contrary, when he came to Rome, he searched hard for me and
found me –

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 1:18–18

18 may the Lord grant him to find mercy from the Lord on that day! – and you know better than I do how much he served in Ephesus.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἀναζωπυρέω

anazōpyreō · “rekindle”

A verb found only here in the New Testament: ana (again), zōos (alive), pyr (fire) – bellows worked over smouldering coals until the ash blows away. Timothy's gift is not dead, but fear and tears have let a layer of ash settle over it (1:6).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἐπαισχύνομαι

epaischynomai · “be ashamed”

The key word of 1:8–18 occurs three times: as a call to Timothy (v. 8), as Paul's own testimony (v. 12), and as the badge of honour of Onesiphorus, who “was not ashamed of my chain” (v. 16).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

παραθήκη

parathēkē · “my entrusted deposit”

A banking and legal term for something handed over for safekeeping. In 1:12 the Greek leaves open whether it is what Paul has entrusted to God or what God has entrusted to Paul; in 1:14 it is clearly the sound teaching entrusted to Timothy.

THE BIG IDEA

God did not give us a spirit of cowardice: because Christ has broken the power of death and God guards what is entrusted, we can rekindle his gift and stand unashamed with the gospel and with his suffering people.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Paul is in chains and expecting death, yet he opens with “the promise of the life that is in Christ Jesus” and with gratitude. What does that tell you about where his hope is anchored?

2 Timothy 1:1–5

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Timothy's faith “lived first in your grandmother Lois and in your mother Eunice”. Who passed the faith on to you – and why does Paul add “it lives in you as well”?

2 Timothy 1:5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“Rekindle the gift of God” – the gift is under ash, not dead. What kinds of “ash” settle on our faith and our gifts today?

2 Timothy 1:6

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Verse 7 names a “spirit of cowardice” – not natural caution, but shrinking back from what God calls us to. Where do we hide fear behind good excuses? What would power, love and self-control look like instead?

2 Timothy 1:7

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Read verses 9–10 again. How does knowing that grace was given to us “before eternal ages” and that Christ “broke the power of death” give us courage to stand up for the gospel?

2 Timothy 1:8–10

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“I know whom I have believed.” Paul's confidence rests on a Person, not only on facts. What difference does that make when you are under pressure?

2 Timothy 1:12

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Phygelus and Hermogenes turned away; Onesiphorus “searched hard for me and found me”. Who in your world is “chained” by illness, loss or loneliness – and what would it take to be an Onesiphorus to them?

2 Timothy 1:15–18

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one layer of “ash” on your faith or your gifts this week and take one practical step to fan the flame again – prayer, opening the Scriptures, or using a gift you have let lie.
- Be an Onesiphorus: seek out one person who is going through a hard season – visit, call or write – and refresh them.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading verse 7 aloud together. Then pray in pairs: thank God for the people who passed the faith on to you, name one place where fear holds you back, and ask for his power, love and self-control. Close by praying for people you know who are “chained” by hardship.

FAITHFUL TO THE END · SESSION 2

Strengthened by Grace

2 Timothy 2:1–26

TO GET STARTED

Who taught you a skill – cooking, a trade, a sport – that you have since passed on to someone else?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 1 ended with people who turned away and one faithful friend; chapter 2 opens with “You then, my child” – Timothy must stand firm. Paul knows his life will soon end, and his question is how the gospel will go forward when he is no longer there. Tonight we read three pictures of endurance, the unchained word with a hymn of God's faithfulness, and instructions for dealing with false teaching in the church – Hymenaeus and Philetus were saying that the resurrection had already taken place.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 2:1–6

1 You then, my child, be strengthened by the grace that is in Christ Jesus. 2 And the
things you heard from me through many witnesses – entrust these to faithful people
who will be competent to teach others too. 3 Share in hardship as a good soldier of
Christ Jesus. 4 No one serving as a soldier gets entangled in the affairs of everyday
life, since he wants to please the one who enlisted him. 5 Likewise, anyone who
competes as an athlete is not crowned unless he competes according to the rules.
6 The farmer who works hard ought to be the first to receive a share of the crops.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 2:7–11

7 Think about what I am saying, for the Lord will give you understanding in
everything.

8 Remember Jesus Christ, raised from the dead, descended from David, according to
my gospel. 9 For this gospel I am enduring hardship, even to the point of being
chained like a criminal. But the word of God is not chained. 10 That is why I endure
all things for the sake of the chosen, so that they too may obtain the salvation that is
in Christ Jesus, with eternal glory. 11 This is a trustworthy saying:

For if we died with him,
we will also live with him;

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 2:12–14

12 if we endure,
we will also reign with him;
if we will deny him,
he also will deny us;
13 if we are faithless,
he remains faithful –
for he cannot deny himself.
14 Keep reminding them of these things, and solemnly charge them before the Lord not to fight about words; it is of no use and only ruins those who listen.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 2:15–18

15 Make every effort to present yourself to God as approved, a worker with nothing
to be ashamed of, who handles the word of truth accurately. 16 But avoid irreverent,
empty chatter, for those who indulge in it will advance further and further into
ungodliness, 17 and their talk will spread like gangrene. Among them are
Hymenaeus and Philetus, 18 who have missed the mark concerning the truth by
saying that the resurrection has already taken place, and they are overturning the
faith of some.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 2:19–21

19 Yet the solid foundation laid by God stands firm, and it bears this seal: "The Lord knows who are his," and: "Everyone who names the name of the Lord must turn away from wrongdoing."

20 In a large house you find not only vessels of gold and silver, but also vessels of wood and clay – some meant for honour, others for dishonour. 21 So if anyone purifies himself from these, he will be a vessel meant for honour – consecrated, useful to the master, prepared for every good work.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 2:22–26

22 Flee from the desires of youth, and pursue righteousness, faith, love and peace,
together with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart. 23 Refuse foolish and
uninstructed controversies, knowing that they give rise to quarrels. 24 And a servant
of the Lord must not quarrel, but be kind to everyone, able to teach, patient when
wronged, 25 instructing with gentleness those who oppose him, in the hope that God
may grant them repentance that leads to the knowledge of the truth, 26 and they will
come to their senses and escape from the trap of the devil, having been taken
captive by him for his will.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ἐνδυναμοῦ

endynamou · “be strengthened”

Present tense and usually understood as passive (2:1): keep on letting yourself be made strong by the grace that is in Christ Jesus. Strength is not generated from within; it is received from Christ's grace.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ὀρθοτομέω

orthotomeō · “handle accurately”

Found only here in the New Testament, literally “cutting straight” – a stonemason, a ploughman's furrow, a straight road, or Paul the tentmaker cutting along a pattern. False teachers cut Scripture crooked; the approved worker is one “who handles the word of truth accurately” (2:15).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

σκεῦος εἰς τιμήν

skeuos eis timēn · "a vessel meant for honour"

In a large house some vessels serve at the table, others carry out the waste (2:20). But unlike a clay pot, anyone who purifies himself "will be a vessel meant for honour – consecrated, useful to the master" (2:21). Purity, not status, makes us useful.

THE BIG IDEA

Strengthened by grace and remembering the risen Christ, we pass the unchained word on to faithful people, handle it accurately and meet even our opponents with gentleness – because he remains faithful.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Paul says “be strengthened by the grace”. What is the difference between trying to be strong for God in our own strength and letting his grace make us strong?

2 Timothy 2:1

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Verse 2 describes four generations: Paul, Timothy, “faithful people” and “others”. Why does Paul look first for faithful people rather than brilliant ones? Whose life are you investing in?

2 Timothy 2:2

DISCUSSION · 3/7

Soldier, athlete, farmer: undivided focus, no shortcuts, patient hard work. Which of the three pictures speaks to you most right now – and why?

2 Timothy 2:3–7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

“Remember Jesus Christ, raised from the dead.” When problems fill your whole field of vision, what helps you keep the risen Christ before your eyes?

2 Timothy 2:8

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Paul is chained “like a criminal”, “but the word of God is not chained”. Where do you feel limited or “chained” – and how might God's word still move through you?

2 Timothy 2:9

DISCUSSION · 6/7

Read the hymn in verses 11–13 again. Which line comforts you, and which line warns you? What does “he remains faithful” mean to you on a weak day?

2 Timothy 2:11–13

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Verses 24–26: a servant of the Lord must not quarrel, but be kind, patient when wronged, and correct with gentleness. Think of someone who opposes your faith. What would gentleness look like in your next conversation?

2 Timothy 2:24–26

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one of the “faithful people” around you – a younger colleague, a child or grandchild, someone new to faith – and arrange a coffee in the next two weeks to open the Scriptures and pray together.
- Each morning this week, before you look at your phone, read 2:8 and tell yourself: “Remember Jesus Christ.” Then name one situation in which you will trust his unchained word.

PRAY TOGETHER

Read the hymn of 2:11–13 aloud together. Then pray in threes: for strength from grace in a place where you feel exhausted, for the faithful people you want to invest in, and with gentleness for someone who opposes the faith – that God may grant them repentance that leads to the knowledge of the truth.

FAITHFUL TO THE END · SESSION 3

Remain in the Word

2 Timothy 3:1–17

TO GET STARTED

Who taught you something important – not in a classroom, but by letting you watch how they lived? What did you pick up from them?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

At the end of chapter 2 Paul told Timothy to treat the misled with gentleness and patience. Now he warns him not to be naive: the “last days” – the whole period between Christ's first coming and his return – bring difficult times, even inside the church. Tonight we read chapter 3: a portrait of religion that is only an outer shell, and Paul's answer – a life lived in the open and the Scriptures breathed out by God.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 3:1–5

1 But understand this: in the last days difficult times will come. 2 For people will be
lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boastful, arrogant, blasphemers, disobedient
to their parents, ungrateful, unholy, 3 heartless, irreconcilable, slanderers, without
self-restraint, brutal, haters of what is good, 4 treacherous, reckless, puffed up,
lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, 5 having an outward form of godliness
but denying its power. Turn away from such people!

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 3:6–10

6 For among them are those who worm their way into households and take captive
weak women, who are weighed down with sins and driven by all kinds of desires,
7 always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth. 8 Just as
Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses, so these also oppose the truth: people
corrupted in mind, who have failed the test regarding the faith. 9 But they will not
get very far, for their folly will become plain to everyone, as happened with those
two.

10 You, however, have closely followed my teaching, my way of life, my purpose, my
faith, my patience, my love, my endurance,

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 3:11–15

11 my persecutions and my sufferings, the things that happened to me in Antioch, in
Iconium and in Lystra. What persecutions I bore! And the Lord rescued me from all
of them. 12 Indeed, all who want to live in godliness in Christ Jesus will be
persecuted. 13 But evil people and impostors will go from bad to worse, deceiving
and being deceived. 14 But you, remain in what you have learned and have become
convinced of, knowing from whom you learned it, 15 and that from childhood you
have known the sacred writings, which can give you the wisdom that leads to
salvation through faith in Christ Jesus.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 3:16–17

16 All Scripture is God-breathed and useful for teaching, for reproof, for correction,
for training in righteousness, 17 so that the man of God may be fully capable,
equipped for every good work.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

φίλαυτοι … φιλόθεοι

philautoi … philotheoi · "lovers of themselves … lovers of God"

Paul frames the list with words built on *philos* (love): it begins with "lovers of themselves" and ends with "lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God" (3:2, 4). The root of the decay is disordered love – when love of self pushes out love of God, relationships fall apart.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

μόρφωσις εὐσεβείας

morphōsis eusebeias · "outward form of godliness"

A *morphōsis* is an outward form or shell. These people are "having an outward form of godliness but denying its power" (3:5): the right words and the right meetings, but no *dynamis* – no power of the Spirit that changes the heart.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

θεόπνευστος

theopneustos · "God-breathed"

The word occurs only here in the New Testament (3:16): Scripture is breathed out by God. When Scripture speaks, God speaks – and so it is useful "for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness".

THE BIG IDEA

In difficult times an outward form of godliness is not enough; what keeps us standing is the God-breathed Scripture, learned from people whose lives we have seen up close.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Read the list in verses 2–4 again. Which of these marks do you recognise most in our culture today? Why might the list begin with “lovers of themselves”?

2 Timothy 3:1–4

DISCUSSION · 2/7

Paul is describing people who are “having an outward form of godliness but denying its power”. What could that look like in a church – and, honestly, in my own life?

2 Timothy 3:5

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth” – how is it possible to take in many sermons, podcasts and books and still not change?

2 Timothy 3:7

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses by imitating his miracles. Where do we meet imitations of true faith today, and how can we tell the difference?

2 Timothy 3:8–9

DISCUSSION · 5/7

Timothy had closely followed Paul's life – including what happened in Lystra, probably his home town. Who has let you see their faith up close? And who is watching yours?

2 Timothy 3:10–11

DISCUSSION · 6/7

“all who want to live in godliness in Christ Jesus will be persecuted.” Do we expect the Christian life to be comfortable? What has following Christ cost you?

2 Timothy 3:12

DISCUSSION · 7/7

Scripture is useful “for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness”. Which of these four do you welcome easily – and which do you tend to avoid?

2 Timothy 3:16–17

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Take one Bible passage each day this week and ask four questions: What does it teach me? Where does it reprove me? What does it want to set straight? How does it train me in righteousness?
- Spend time this week with someone younger in faith – a child, a grandchild or a new believer – and tell them about one time when God carried you through something hard.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a minute of silence, asking God to show you any area where you are content with an outward form. Then pray together: thank God for his God-breathed Word, for the parents, grandparents and mentors who passed it on to you, and pray for the children and young people in your lives.

FAITHFUL TO THE END · SESSION 4

Finish the Race

2 Timothy 4:1–22

TO GET STARTED

Think of a finish line you have crossed – a race, an exam, a big project, a long journey. What kept you going near the end?

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Paul is in chains in Rome, probably around AD 66 or 67; winter is coming and he knows his death is near. Chapter 4 holds the last words we have from his pen: a solemn charge to Timothy, a look back on his finished race, and very personal requests and greetings. Tonight we close the series with Paul's last words.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 4:1–4

1 I solemnly charge you before God and Christ Jesus, who is going to judge the living
and the dead, and by his appearing and his kingdom: 2 proclaim the word; keep at it
whether the time is right or not; reprove, rebuke, encourage, with all patience and
teaching. 3 For the time will come when people will not put up with sound teaching,
but, following their own desires, will pile up teachers for themselves because their
ears itch, 4 and they will turn their ears away from the truth and wander off to
myths.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 4:5–9

5 But you, be sober-minded in everything, endure hardship, do the work of an evangelist, carry out your service fully.

6 For already I am being poured out as a drink offering, and the time for my departure is here. 7 I have fought the good fight, I have run the race to the end, I have kept the faith. 8 What remains is this: the crown of righteousness is stored up for me, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will give me on that day – and not to me only, but to all who have loved his appearing.

9 Make every effort to come to me soon.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 4:10–15

10 For Demas has abandoned me, because he loved this present age, and has gone to
Thessalonica; Crescens has gone to Galatia, Titus to Dalmatia. 11 Only Luke is with
me. Pick up Mark and bring him along, for he is useful to me for service. 12 I have
sent Tychicus to Ephesus. 13 When you come, bring the cloak that I left with Carpus
in Troas, and the books, especially the parchments. 14 Alexander the metalworker
did me much harm – the Lord will repay him according to his works. 15 You too must
be on your guard against him, for he strongly opposed our words.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 4:16–20

16 At my first defence no one stood by me, but all abandoned me – may it not be
counted against them! 17 But the Lord stood by me and gave me strength, so that
through me the proclamation might be fully carried out and all the nations might
hear it; and I was rescued from the mouth of the lion. 18 The Lord will rescue me
from every evil deed and will save me for his heavenly kingdom. To him be the
glory for ever and ever. Amen.

19 Greet Prisca and Aquila and the household of Onesiphorus. 20 Erastus stayed in
Corinth, and I left Trophimus sick in Miletus.

READ TOGETHER · 2 TIMOTHY 4:21–22

21 Make every effort to come before winter. Eubulus greets you, as do Pudens and
Linus and Claudia and all the brothers and sisters.

22 The Lord be with your spirit. Grace be with you all.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

κήρυξον τὸν λόγον

kēryxon ton logon · “proclaim the word”

A *kēryx* was a herald who announced the King's decree in the town square – not his own philosophy. His one duty was faithfulness to the message of the one who sent him, “whether the time is right or not” (4:2).

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

σπένδομαι / ἀνάλυσις

spendomai / analysis · "poured out as a drink offering … departure"

"For already I am being poured out as a drink offering" (4:6): Paul sees his execution not as a wasted life but as a last offering of worship. *Analysis* was used of loosing a ship's mooring ropes – death as setting sail for home.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

ὁ δὲ κύριός μοι παρέστη

ho de kyrios moi parestē · "the Lord stood by me"

Paristēmi means to come and stand right beside someone – in court, like an advocate beside the accused. When no one stood by Paul, "the Lord stood by me and gave me strength" (4:17).

THE BIG IDEA

Because Scripture is God's voice and Christ is the coming Judge, we proclaim the word whether the time is right or not – and when everyone else leaves, the Lord stands by his servant and brings him safely home.

DISCUSSION · 1/7

Paul gives his charge “before God and Christ Jesus, who is going to judge the living and the dead”. How does living before the coming King change the way we speak and serve?

2 Timothy 4:1–2

DISCUSSION · 2/7

People “will pile up teachers for themselves because their ears itch”. Where are we tempted to listen only to what we want to hear? How do you react when the Word reproves you?

2 Timothy 4:3–4

DISCUSSION · 3/7

“I have fought the good fight, I have run the race to the end, I have kept the faith.” The crown is for “all who have loved his appearing”. What does it look like to love Christ's appearing in everyday life?

2 Timothy 4:7–8

DISCUSSION · 4/7

Demas “loved this present age”; Mark, who once deserted Paul, is now “useful to me for service”. What do these two stories say to someone who started strong – and to someone who has failed?

2 Timothy 4:10–11

DISCUSSION · 5/7

About Alexander Paul says “the Lord will repay him according to his works”; about those who left him, “may it not be counted against them!” How does Paul handle people who hurt him? Is there someone you need to leave with God or forgive?

2 Timothy 4:14–16

DISCUSSION · 6/7

When have you known that the Lord stood by you when people could not or would not? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

2 Timothy 4:17–18

DISCUSSION · 7/7

As we finish 2 Timothy: which verse from these four chapters will you take with you, and why?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Think of a “Mark” – someone who has failed or drifted and feels written off. Contact them this week with a word of encouragement.
- Choose one verse from 2 Timothy as your verse for the road, learn it by heart, and tell one person why you chose it.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God that the Lord stood by Paul and stands by us. Pray for people who stand alone right now – in a hospital room, a courtroom or at a grave. Then read 4:18 aloud together: “The Lord will rescue me from every evil deed and will save me for his heavenly kingdom. To him be the glory for ever and ever. Amen.” The leader closes with 4:22 as a blessing.